

US Rates Research: Flow of Funds

Who has been buying US debt?

The Fed's flow of funds data show that fixed income issuance rose in Q1 on heavier corporate supply. For both the quarter and the past year, mutual funds, foreign investors, and pensions/insurance companies remained the dominant buyers, with banks stepping up their purchases.

The Fed recently released its Z1 data series (known as the flow of funds) for Q1 26,¹ which sheds light on fixed income supply and demand dynamics.

Quarter over quarter, net issuance rose about \$250bn, driven by a sharp rebound in corporate bond supply, alongside modestly higher agency and muni issuance, while Treasury ex-T-bills supply declined somewhat. On the demand side, both domestic and foreign investors stepped up, particularly banks.

On a year over year basis, net supply to investors on a four-quarter basis declined from \$3.4tn to \$2.9tn, led by Treasuries ex-Bills. Mutual funds, foreign investors, and pensions/insurance remained the dominant buyers, with banks and MMFs also stepping up their purchases.

Flow of funds in Q1 26 versus Q4 25

Figure 1 and Figure 2 show the breakdown of net demand for and supply of fixed income across key investor groups and asset classes for Q1 26 and Q4 25, respectively.

Net issuance rose to \$748bn in Q1 26, from \$491bn in Q4 25, driven by a \$244bn increase in corporate bond issuance, to \$334bn, alongside higher agency issuance at \$77bn and muni issuance at \$37bn. Treasury issuance ex-T-bills was about \$300bn in Q1, down from \$348bn in Q4. The Fed remained a net seller, adding about \$49bn and mostly agencies to what private investors needed to absorb in Q1, compared with \$59bn in Q4.

Overall, net issuance of fixed income securities to private investors was about \$797bn in Q1, up from \$550bn in Q4 25.

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Please see analyst certifications and important disclosures beginning on page 6.

¹ <https://www.federalreserve.gov/releases/z1/default.htm>

FIGURE 1. Net issuance to private investors across fixed income rose to \$797bn in Q1...

Q1-26, \$bn	Tsy x-bills	Agencies	Munis	Corp. Bonds	Total
Mutual Funds/ETFs	95	10	21	178	304
Banking Sector	95	39	0	65	199
Pensions/Insurance	20	12	-2	139	168
Rest of the World	64	29	-4	143	232
Brokers/Dealers	82	26	0	5	112
Households	-181	-100	26	-214	-468
MMFs	128	87	-5	6	216
Others	2	18	1	13	34
Total to private	305	121	37	334	797
Federal Reserve	-5	-44	0	0	-49
Total	300	77	37	334	748

"Others" includes GSEs, state and local governments, other financial companies, non-financial corporate and non-corporate business, and REITs. Households are estimated as a residual category.

Source: Federal Reserve, Barclays Research

FIGURE 2. ...from \$550bn in Q425

Q4-25, \$bn	Tsy x-bills	Agencies	Munis	Corp. Bonds	Total
Mutual Funds/ETFs	83	13	7	132	235
Banking Sector	10	-28	0	-42	-60
Pensions/Insurance	22	-4	0	112	130
Rest of the World	-23	26	1	79	83
Brokers/Dealers	-24	8	0	-12	-28
Households	247	10	4	-183	78
MMFs	50	14	15	4	84
Others	-6	36	-1	-1	28
Total to private	359	75	26	90	550
Federal Reserve	-11	-48	0	0	-59
Total	348	27	26	90	491

"Others" includes GSEs, state and local governments, other financial companies, non-financial corporate and non-corporate business, and REITs. Households are estimated as a residual category.

Source: Federal Reserve, Barclays Research

On the demand side, final investors stepped up across the board, with q/q increase led by banks, foreign investors, broker/dealers, and MMFs, while mutual funds as well as the pension and insurance sector remained strong buyers overall. Household sector was estimated to be a net seller.

- In Q1, mutual funds and ETFs were the largest buyers of US debt, with net purchases of \$304bn, up from \$235bn in Q4. A large part of their purchases were corporate bonds at \$178bn, followed by Treasuries at \$95bn, with agencies and munis consisting of \$10bn and \$21bn, respectively.
- Bank demand swung sharply higher, rising to \$199bn from net selling of \$60bn in Q4, and was well above the recent quarterly pace. The demand was broad based, with banks buying \$95bn of Treasuries, \$39bn of agencies, and \$65bn of corporate bonds in Q1.
 - Our [Q1 bank securities report](#) based on aggregated Y-9C data shows that US banks' balance sheet growth re-accelerated, led by the GSIBs and driven by securities additions. The expansion, along with sizable growth in banks' repo books, points to an increase in balance sheet capacity and intermediation, likely reflecting banks' taking advantage of the SLR relief.
- Demand from broker/dealers also rose, they added \$112bn in Q1 and largely in Treasuries (\$82bn), a reversal from a \$28bn net reduction in Q4.
- Foreign investors also stepped up, net buying \$232bn in Q1 after purchasing \$83bn in Q4. Their demand was skewed toward corporate bonds, of which they bought \$143bn, followed by Treasuries (ex-bills) at \$64bn, along with \$65bn in T-bills, while agency demand was slightly negative at -\$4bn.
 - Based on Treasury TIC data, foreign demand was almost entirely driven by the private sector in Q1. The official sector sold \$13bn in long-term USTs, but added \$53bn in T-bills and \$17bn in corporate bonds.
- In terms of the regional breakdown, demand in Q1 was largely driven by Europe, which bought \$200bn in US long-term debt and half of which was in USTs, though this may reflect

some custodial activities. Asia added T-bills but turned into a net seller of long-term debt for the quarter, as Japan and mainland China turned net sellers after stepping up purchases in January (see [here](#)).

- Pensions and insurance companies remained steady absorbers of supply, purchasing \$168bn in Q1, up from \$130bn in Q4. Their demand remained concentrated in corporate bonds at \$139bn, with smaller purchases of Treasuries at \$20bn and agencies at \$12bn.
- MMFs stepped up meaningfully, buying \$216bn in Q1 versus \$84bn in Q4. Over half of their purchases was in Treasuries (\$128bn) as they rotated from T-bills (-\$219bn) into coupons, followed by agencies at \$87bn, while munis were slightly negative and corporate bond demand remained small.
- Households (a residual category that includes domestic hedge funds, private equity funds and personal trusts), by contrast, swung sharply into net selling, offloading \$468bn in Q1 after buying \$78bn in Q4. After adding \$247bn of Treasuries (ex-bills) in Q4, households reversed course in Q1, selling \$181bn, while simultaneously moving back into T-bills, adding over \$200bn after shedding a similar amount the prior quarter. They also reduced corporate bonds again by \$214bn and agencies by \$100bn, though remained modest buyers of munis at \$26bn.

Flow of funds for the 12 months through Q1 26

Quarter to quarter, there is generally significant volatility in flows. [Figure 3](#) and [Figure 4](#) show the net demand for and supply of fixed income securities (ex-bills) for the four quarters ending Q1 26 and Q1 25, respectively.

Net supply to investors on a four-quarter basis declined from \$3.4tn to \$2.9tn. Treasury issuance fell the most but remained the largest component at \$1.6tn, followed by corporate issuance at \$705bn, agencies at \$462bn, and munis at \$165bn.

Who bought these? **Mutual funds, overseas investors, and pension funds/insurance companies were the largest net buyers, absorbing over 75% of the total supply to investors, while households swung into net selling.**

- Mutual funds were the largest source of demand, net buying \$829bn over the four quarters through Q1 26, up from \$592bn in the prior year. Their purchases were largely split between corporate bonds at \$427bn and Treasuries at \$327bn.
- The foreign sector remained a major buyer, with net purchases of \$749bn, though that was down from \$842bn in the four-quarters prior. Foreign demand was led by corporate bonds, with \$404bn in purchases. This was followed by Treasuries at \$240bn, with additional \$104bn of buying in agencies.
- Pensions and insurance companies purchased \$638bn over the year, up from \$482bn in the prior period. Their buying was again led by corporate bonds at \$435bn, followed by Treasuries at \$118bn and agencies at \$84bn.
- Bank demand increased notably, with the sector net buying \$267bn versus \$109bn in the prior year, and again mostly in Treasuries. Banks accumulated \$279bn of Treasuries, while agency and corporate demand remained close to flat to slightly negative over the past year.
- MMFs also stepped up, purchasing \$537bn over the four quarters through Q1 26, up from \$404bn in the prior period. Their demand was centered in Treasuries at \$313bn and agencies at \$198bn.

- The household sector, by contrast, net sold \$558bn after buying \$594bn in the prior year. The reversal was driven primarily by corporate bond sales of \$604bn and a \$135bn reduction in agencies, while the sector remained a modest net buyer of Treasuries and munis, adding \$78bn and \$103bn, respectively.

FIGURE 3. Net supply to private investors fell from \$3.4tn to \$2.9tn...

LTM Q1'26, bn	Tsy x-bills	Agencies	Munis	Corp. Bonds	Total
Mutual Funds/ETFs	327	28	47	427	829
Banking Sector	279	-12	0	-1	267
Pensions/Insurance	118	84	1	435	638
Rest of the World	240	104	0	404	749
Brokers/Dealers	130	81	0	0	210
Households	78	-135	103	-604	-558
MMFs	313	198	12	15	537
Others	92	114	2	30	239
Total to private	1,578	462	165	705	2,910
Federal Reserve	-48	-198	0	0	-246
Total	1,530	264	165	705	2,664

"Others" includes GSEs, state and local governments, other financial companies, non-financial corporate and non-corporate business, and REITs. Households are estimated as a residual category.

Source: Federal Reserve, Barclays Research

FIGURE 4. ...mutual funds, overseas investors, and pensions/insurance absorbed most of it

LTM Q1'25, bn	Tsy x-bills	Agencies	Munis	Corp. Bonds	Total
Mutual Funds/ETFs	199	38	44	310	592
Banking Sector	104	44	-26	-14	109
Pensions/Insurance	115	62	-20	326	482
Rest of the World	501	44	5	291	842
Brokers/Dealers	74	123	0	-10	186
Households	612	-7	87	-98	594
MMFs	218	174	10	2	404
Others	138	46	4	10	198
Total to private	1,961	524	105	816	3,406
Federal Reserve	-417	-205	0	0	-622
Total	1,544	319	105	816	2,784

"Others" includes GSEs, state and local governments, other financial companies, non-financial corporate and non-corporate business, and REITs. Households are estimated as a residual category.

Source: Federal Reserve, Barclays Research

Pension and insurance sectors

Figure 5 and Figure 6 show net demand from pension/insurance companies for the four quarters ending Q1 26 and Q1 25, respectively, given their importance for long-end rates.

The overall pace of net purchases across the sectors rose to about \$637bn, compared with \$481bn in the prior year. The increase was driven primarily by insurance companies, which added \$419bn, mostly in corporate bonds (\$353bn). They also bought \$48bn in agencies and \$17bn in Treasuries.

Pension funds purchased \$218bn, up from \$202bn in the prior year, with state and local pensions accounting for over half of the overall demand (\$126bn) while defined contribution plans bought \$72bn. Private DB plans were little changed at \$21bn. In contrast to the insurance sector, pensions allocated about half of their purchases to Treasuries (\$101bn). Taken together, the pension and insurance sectors continued to provide a stable base of long-duration demand.

FIGURE 5. Insurance and pensions demand rose...

LTM Q1'26 ,bn	Tsy x-bills	Agencies	Munis	Corp. Bonds	Total
Total insurance	17	48	1	353	419
Life insurance	14	19	-4	268	298
Other insurance	3	29	4	85	121
Total pensions	101	35	0	82	218
State/local pensions	46	23	0	56	126
Private pensions, DB	21	9	0	-9	21
Private pensions, DC	34	4	0	34	72
Total	118	83	1	434	637

Source: Federal Reserve, Barclays Research

FIGURE 6. ...largely in corporate bonds

LTM Q1'25 ,bn	Tsy x-bills	Agencies	Munis	Corp. Bonds	Total
Total insurance	14	35	-20	250	279
Life insurance	2	-2	-14	188	173
Other insurance	12	37	-6	62	106
Total pensions	101	26	0	75	202
State/local pensions	53	13	0	53	120
Private pensions, DB	21	8	0	-9	21
Private pensions, DC	27	5	0	31	62
Total	115	62	-20	325	481

Source: Federal Reserve, Barclays Research

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